

Chapter 174-4

All in all, she was just too timid.

Every time Liang Shi chatted with Xu Qingzhu about the old Zhao Xuning, she felt like it wasn't the same person as the current one.

The former Zhao Xuning was spirited, confident and proud. But the current Zhao Xuning was gloomy, like a soulless shell—waking up numbly each day, working numbly, sleeping numbly.

There wasn't a trace of the brilliance of a genius girl on her face, only an aura of impending death.

Even though Shen Hui said she had let her go.

And would no longer be entangled with her.

She still couldn't let herself go. Occasionally, she would go to Shen Hui's hospital to take a look, just standing outside the hospital smoking a cigarette, before going to work.

Once, when Liang Shi went to eat with her, they ran into Shen Hui and her girlfriend.

It should be the college classmate Zhao Xuning had mentioned before. She had proper looks and was quite considerate, always smiling at Shen Hui when she spoke. Liang Shi got the feeling she was somewhat flattering and insincere. Before leaving, she even came over specifically to greet Zhao Xuning, her words not very polite. Shen Hui just watched.

Liang Shi didn't really like that woman. She looked like she was approaching Shen Hui with some ulterior motive.

Later, Zhao Xuning said it was because that person's family didn't have much money. They used to run a company, but it went bankrupt when they were in college.

Looking so mercenary was probably because of this.

But most importantly, this person didn't have much genuine feelings for Shen Hui.

Liang Shi urged Zhao Xuning to go and make Shen Hui stay, but Zhao Xuning walked to the doorway, stared at the two figures until they disappeared, smoked a cigarette, and went back inside.

Liang Shi cursed her for being too cowardly.

Zhao Xuning only curved her lips slightly without saying anything.

At that moment, Zhao Xuning's eyes were red, with tears, and an emotion called fear.

Later, one day Zhao Xuning was drinking away her sorrows at a bar. After getting drunk, she said something to Liang Shi.

She said: "Only now do I know I love her too much. So I'm afraid she won't be doing well without me, and even more afraid that she's not doing well."

Zhao Xuning's voice was hoarse. She told Liang Shi: "I could go and make her stay, but would that be the right thing to do? What if we repeat our old mistakes? I'm afraid of seeing her disgust. I'm even more afraid that I'll keep her, but won't be able to give her happiness."

Out of ten thousand reconciliations, nine thousand nine hundred end up repeating the same mistakes.

Zhao Xuning didn't dare to gamble.

Didn't dare to try to make her stay.

After that time, Liang Shi never dared to mention anything related to Shen Hui again.

No matter how miserable Zhao Xuning felt, she absolutely refused to use Shen Hui's name to provoke or hurt her.

That was Zhao Xuning's true soft spot.

To be loved so stubbornly by someone could also be considered a kind of fortune.

Now, Shen Hui was getting engaged—things were about to be settled.

Liang Shi felt quite emotional after hearing this.

But she and Xu Qingzhu were both outsiders, powerless to do anything about it.

However, Liang Shi had an interview that day. During a break in the middle of the interview, she heard some staff members discussing: "What the hell? What kind of grudge is this? She's actually kneeling her way up three thousand steps?"

"I'm not saying anything, but are young people these days really this dramatic when dating?"

"The key is she's so good-looking. Why hang herself on one tree?"¹

"What do you mean? I heard these two broke up. Now one of them is getting engaged and was on the mountain with her fiancée to enjoy the scenery. Then the ex-girlfriend showed up saying she couldn't get engaged or something. The other woman got angry and said if she could kneel and bow her way up all three thousand steps to Huichang Temple at the mountaintop today, she wouldn't get engaged."

"That's a thing? What kind of pitiful ex-girlfriend is this?"

"If she were ugly, I'd curse her for bringing it on herself. But she's so good-looking, and she's wearing a white coat. I... feel like I'm watching a xianxia drama."²

"Someone dug up that this is Zhao Ying's cousin!"

"What? No way? Her ex-girlfriend is a goddess? She has to do this?"

"Who knows with matters of the heart? But honestly, the way she kneels and climbs step by step, she looks so shattered. It breaks my heart watching it."

"People online really think she's filming a drama, not trying to win back her ex-girlfriend. They just can't see any cameras, hahaha."

"....."

Everyone was discussing enthusiastically. It was evening, with crimson clouds spreading across the horizon. Liang Shi caught the words "Zhao Ying's cousin"—wasn't that Zhao Xuning?

She then asked her assistant for her phone. There were no messages.

But there was a trending topic on hot search: #Zhao Ying's Cousin Three Thousand Steps#.

"Three thousand steps" was actually an exaggeration. There was a mountain on the outskirts of Haizhou City with Huichang Temple on top. It was said to be especially effective for praying for marriage and children. Most people took the cable car from the foot of the mountain to Huichang Temple at the top, but there was a mountain path with over two thousand steps according to incomplete statistics, jokingly called the "Three Thousand Steps."

In the past, some people had walked the three thousand steps with a bow at each step, mostly praying for blessings for their children.

In recent years, everyone was used to taking the cable car—they couldn't even be bothered to walk up, let alone kneel and bow with each step.

Liang Shi saw Zhao Xuning's photos online. Her clean white coat was stained with dust. When she left Liang Shi's home this morning, she was wearing black high-waisted wide-leg pants with a white shirt on top—almost her unchanging look throughout the year.

Her light brown straight hair was tied in a low ponytail, casually put up without any aesthetic appeal to speak of.

But her face would add glory to anything.

Even the most ordinary clothes looked beautiful on her.

The most circulated content online was a video of about ten seconds.

Zhao Xuning's complexion was somewhat pale. She didn't look at the path ahead, just woodenly and devoutly bowing, her forehead also dirty. A few strands of hair hung by her face. It was truly one step, one bow—every movement was very standard.

Originally, climbing three thousand steps with a bow at each step wouldn't be such a big deal.

But Zhao Xuning was too good-looking, plus today was Huichang Temple's annual temple celebration, so there were many people from all over the country.

At first, people thought they were filming a drama, but later discovered there were no cameras.

Combined with the fact that someone had seen Zhao Xuning arguing with Shen Hui, that's what led to everything after.

At first, it was just a topic about a devoted woman trying to win back her girlfriend. Later, someone discovered this person had posted a photo with Zhao Ying on Weibo before—she was Zhao Ying's doctor cousin.

There are no secrets on the internet.

And so Zhao Xuning ended up on hot search.

Even though it was under Zhao Ying's famous name.

Liang Shi stared at that video and watched it three times. Zhao Xuning's complexion in the video looked very wrong. She already had a slight fever when she left her home this morning—how could she possibly endure this?

Liang Shi sent Xu Qingzhu a message: [Did you see the hot search? Zhao Xuning.]

Xu Qingzhu replied after a while: [Just finished a meeting. What happened?]

Liang Shi: [...She's gone crazy.]

There was no other explanation besides going crazy.

Xu Qingzhu also finished reading the hot search and sent her a screen full of ellipses.

Liang Shi forwarded the video that netizens posted to Xu Qingzhu: [She's probably still running a fever. If she rolls down the steps later... that would be a tragedy.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Forget it, I'll go find her.]

Liang Shi: [Don't. She's already climbed so high. Don't tire yourself out. I'll go. I'm almost done here.]

Xu Qingzhu: [I'll try calling her.]

After a while, Xu Qingzhu said again: [Can't get through.]

Liang Shi also tried to contact Zhao Xuning, but the call really couldn't get through.

The interview here still needed to be wrapped up. Liang Shi urged the staff to cut two questions and finished the interview as quickly as possible. As soon as the interview ended, she immediately ran out and drove to the outskirts of the city.

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1. "在一棵樹上吊死" (hang oneself on one tree) is a Chinese idiom meaning to stubbornly fixate on one option or person when there are other possibilities, similar to "putting all your eggs in one basket" in terms of romantic pursuits. ↵
 2. Xianxia (仙俠) - A genre of Chinese fantasy involving immortals, martial arts, and cultivation. These dramas often feature dramatic scenes of devotion and sacrifice for love. ↵